

Gentleday — 3IXD Dev 5 Assignment 1 Report

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Repository: `ps786586785857867978/local-productivity-system-dev5`

Product: Gentleday

Platform: macOS desktop

Local-first productivity, focus tracking, and append-only Obsidian history

1. Executive summary

Gentleday is a local-first macOS productivity application that combines task management, recurring daily routines, focus and break tracking, durable local persistence, and append-only Markdown logging to a user-selected Obsidian vault.

The project responds to a personal workflow that mixes coursework with health, language learning, drawing, movement, and reading. Instead of rewarding only perfect Pomodoro sessions, Gentleday records completed, cancelled, paused, and early-completed work honestly. Paused time is excluded from active duration, unfinished one-off tasks remain visible, and the interface uses calm, non-punitive progress feedback.

The final implementation is an Electron, React, and TypeScript desktop application. It passes 30 automated tests, TypeScript checking, a production build, macOS ARM64 packaging, real Electron QA, packaged-app QA, two independent review cycles, and clean-clone verification.

2. Research and product direction

I compared three task-management products and three focus products before defining the feature set.

Todoist demonstrated the value of fast capture, optional metadata, priority, recurring dates, and a compact view of current work.[1] Quire showed how one task model can support strong hierarchy and multiple views, but also helped define what to exclude from a small personal tool: deep nesting, enterprise reporting, and collaboration.[2] Evernote Tasks showed the importance of keeping tasks connected to context, while reinforcing that Gentleday should not become a second note editor because Obsidian already provides that role.[3]

Forest showed how a growing visual metaphor can make focus feel meaningful without requiring a competitive score.[4] PomoTime reinforced familiar work/break phases, editable durations, and completion notifications.[5] Pomofocus provided the clearest reference for connecting a timer to a specific task and reviewing session history.[6]

The research produced three main design principles:

1. task capture should remain fast, with metadata optional;
2. focus history should retain real active time, including interrupted sessions;
3. the app should stay offline and let the user own the resulting history as readable Markdown.

Features such as accounts, collaboration, social focus rooms, reward currencies, enterprise views, and cloud synchronization were deliberately excluded.

3. Grill session and requirements

The Grill session converted the broad assignment into testable decisions. The main user plans with a mixture of Today, deadlines, life areas, and priority. Starting life areas were defined as Health, Learning, Creative, Movement, and Coursework.

The task lifecycle includes creation, editing, completion, reopening, deletion, and daily recurrence. Daily routines create a new occurrence at local midnight without deleting previous history. Deleting a recurring task asks whether to remove one occurrence or the entire routine.

The timer defaults to 25 minutes of focus, a 5-minute short break, and a 15-minute long break. Pause is resumable and does not count toward active duration. Stop creates a cancelled session with its real active time. Reaching zero or selecting Complete creates a completed session with actual rather than planned duration. The next phase always starts manually after a notification.

The Obsidian requirement became an append-only event outbox. Important task, focus, and break actions first become local events. When a vault is available, those events are appended to predictable daily Markdown files. When it is unavailable, work continues and events remain queued for automatic or manual retry.

4. Design development

Three design artifacts were created and reviewed before production styling:

1. a dashboard wireframe to test the combined Today-list and timer hierarchy;
2. a visual style study comparing Sage Studio, Warm Paper, and Night Orchard;
3. a focus-state prototype showing running, paused, break, completed, and unavailable-vault states.

The approved direction uses Sage Studio for the main interface: warm paper surfaces, sage accents, serif display type, restrained shadows, and low-pressure language. Night Orchard informed the optional distraction-free focus state.

The final layout keeps Today tasks beside the timer, with History and Settings as secondary screens. A small original plant scene communicates progress without points or collectible rewards. The progress display can be disabled, and reduced-motion preferences remove nonessential transitions and animation.

Artifact 01 — Dashboard wireframe

Primary surface: Operate + Monitor. Purpose: settle layout and hierarchy before visual styling.

Low fidelity - macOS desktop

Gentleday

Sunday, 27 September

Vault synced

Settings

Today

All tasks

History

LIFE AREAS

Health2

Learning3

Creative1

Movement1

Coursework4

1. Today is the default action surface; routines and deadlines share one list.

4. Optional metadata is readable but never blocks quick capture.

Today

3 of 8 complete

+ Add a task...

Daily routines3 / 5

Morning routine

Health · daily

High

Mandarin lesson

Learning · 30 min

Daily

Drawing practice

Creative · 20 min

Daily

Coursework2 due

Review interaction design notes

Coursework · due today

High

Prepare prototype references

Coursework · due tomorrow

Medium

Focusing on

Review interaction design notes

FOCUS SESSION

18:42

Pause

Complete

Stop

3. Progress is secondary and calm-not a competitive dashboard.

2. Selected task stays visible above the timer to preserve context.

Today's gentle progress

3 focus sessions

Approved Gentleday dashboard wireframe

Artifact 02 — Visual style study

Compare surface treatment, color posture, type character, and the emotional tone of gentle progress. These are original directions, not copies of the researched products.

Recommended: Sage Studio

Sage Studio

CALM · TACTILE · FOCUSED

Today

Mandarin lesson

Drawing practice

Coursework review

FOCUS

18:42

Pause

Small steps, clearly seen.

Humanist sans for controls; restrained serif reserved for reflection and milestones.

WHAT IT DECIDES

Warm off-white surfaces and muted botanical color create gentle progress without resembling a game or wellness cliché.

Strong-fit direction

Warm Paper

PERSONAL · REFLECTIVE · SOFT

Sunday list

Read for 30 minutes

Prepare references

Walk 5,000 steps

ONE THING NOW

18:42

Pause

A quiet page for a real day.

Editorial warmth makes history and reflection inviting, but feels less precise during timed work.

WHAT IT DECIDES

Useful if the final report and Obsidian history become the emotional center; weaker for a glanceable timer dashboard.

Night Orchard

IMMERSIVE · CONTAINED · LOW-LIGHT

Today

Language practice

Creative routine

Assignment draft

FOCUS MODE

18:42

Pause

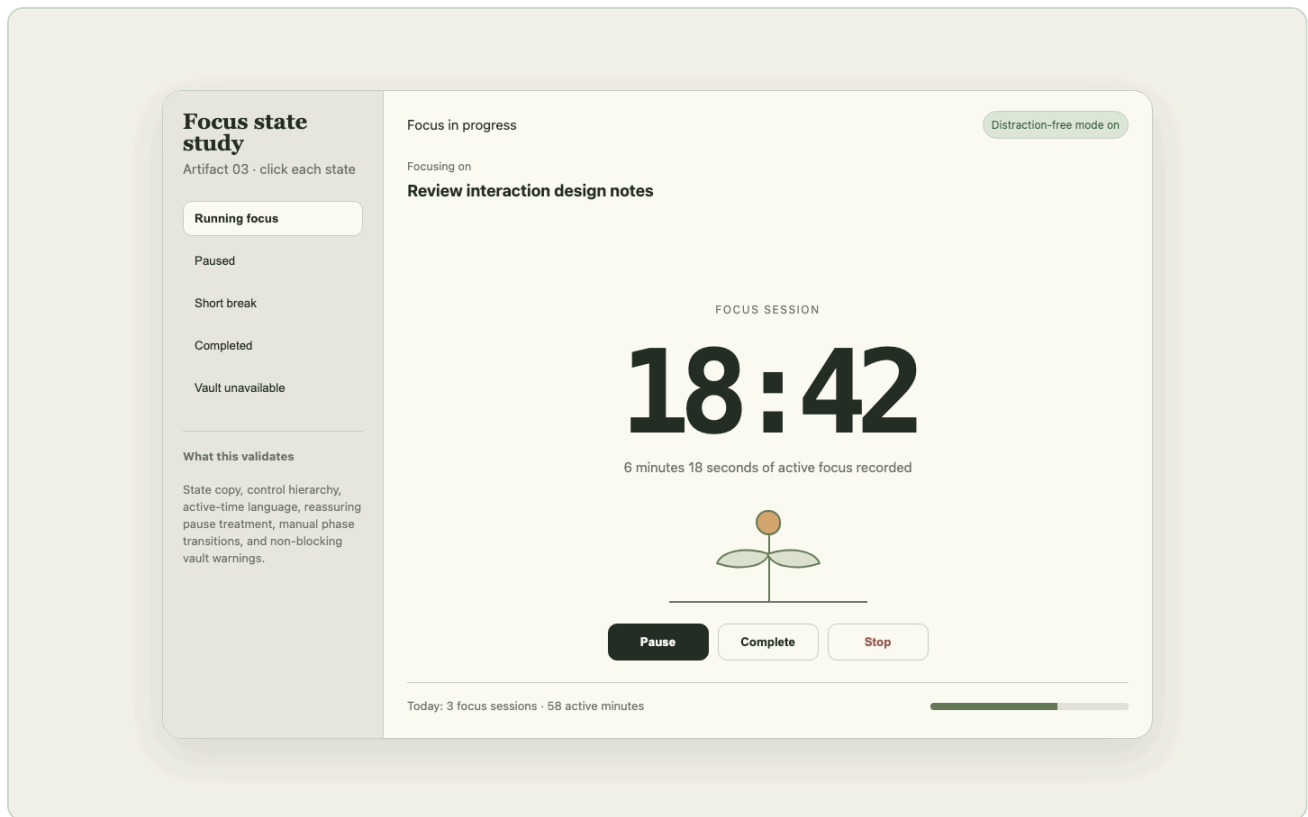
Protect the next twenty-five minutes.

High-contrast numerals and dim surroundings suit focus mode, but may feel heavy as the default task view.

WHAT IT DECIDES

Keep as an optional focus-state treatment rather than the whole application theme.

Approved Sage Studio visual style study



Approved focus-state prototype

No generated or unlicensed character imagery was used. The proposed character-based pause reference was replaced with an original text-and-motion treatment because no suitable user-supplied licensed asset was available.

5. Technical implementation

5.1 Application architecture

Gentleday uses four main layers:

- **Shared product domain:** task commands, recurrence, settings, event generation, and session history;
- **Shared timer domain:** timestamp-derived running and paused states, restart reconstruction, completion, and cancellation;
- **Electron main process:** application lifecycle, state persistence, native folder selection, notifications, validation, and vault writing;
- **React renderer:** Today, History, Settings, task forms, timer controls, progress, and synchronization feedback.

Privileged file operations remain outside the renderer. A narrow preload bridge exposes only the actions needed by the interface.

5.2 Local persistence

Application state is stored as versioned JSON. Saves are serialized, written to unique temporary files, and committed by rename. Invalid on-disk state is quarantined rather than trusted. Runtime validation

checks nested tasks, sessions, timer invariants, settings, timestamps, dates, and outbox events.

The running timer is derived from persisted timestamps rather than a decrementing counter. This allows a running or paused session to be reconstructed accurately after the process closes and reopens.

5.3 Obsidian logging

The user selects a vault through the native macOS folder picker. The main process stores and approves the configured location; the renderer cannot redirect writes to an arbitrary path.

Events are written beneath:

```
Gentleday/Tasks/YYYY/MM/YYYY-MM-DD.md  
Gentleday/Focus/YYYY/MM/YYYY-MM-DD.md  
Gentleday/Breaks/YYYY/MM/YYYY-MM-DD.md
```

Each record contains a stable event ID, local date and time, ISO timestamp, timezone and UTC offset, event type, status, entity ID, and structured JSON details. The writer checks for an existing event ID before appending, so retrying delivery does not duplicate history.

The vault writer also validates canonical paths, filesystem identity, root replacement, symlinks, event structure, bounded metadata, and Markdown-safe output. Queued events retain their original timestamps during a temporary vault outage.

5.4 Desktop security

The production window uses Chromium sandboxing, context isolation, and disabled renderer Node integration. The application restricts IPC to the expected renderer, blocks unexpected navigation and new windows, applies a Content Security Policy, and accepts development renderer overrides only from loopback HTTP origins.

These controls matter because Gentleday writes user-owned local files. The renderer handles presentation, while the main process owns validation and external side effects.

6. Testing and verification

The automated suite contains 30 tests across four files. It covers:

- full task lifecycle and event generation;
- daily recurrence and edited recurring templates;
- Today visibility for unfinished one-off tasks;
- timer pause/resume, completion, cancellation, and active-time accounting;
- Markdown path and record formatting;
- runtime state and event validation;
- serialized atomic persistence;
- duplicate-delivery prevention;
- temporary-vault reconnection;
- symlink and vault-root replacement protection;

- `renderer-origin` policy.

The real Electron QA flow created and edited tasks, completed and reopened work, deleted a temporary task, completed one focus session, cancelled another, completed a short break, and inspected the resulting state through the actual preload/main-process boundary.

A clean clone of final artifact commit `2e0e0b6feaf2dcd66e9cd4a66f6a6de9efa7243e` successfully completed `npm ci`, all 30 tests, type checking, production build, and macOS packaging. The clean-clone packaged application was launched with fresh local data and passed the same main workflow. After a normal application quit and relaunch, it restored five tasks, three sessions, 16 queued events, and no active timer.

Real Obsidian synchronization was also tested using the finished application. The latest verification delivered 16 app-generated events and left zero pending. The original task, focus, and break files remain in the selected vault as evidence.

Detailed results are recorded in `docs/testing/ACCEPTANCE_TESTS.md`.

7. AI use statement

I used Hermes Agent with an OpenAI Codex model as a development assistant for research organization, requirements questioning, implementation, test generation, debugging, code review, and documentation support.

The AI did not make the product decisions independently. I supplied the assignment direction and personal workflow, answered the Grill questions, approved the design references, and confirmed the implementation direction. Every code and documentation change was kept in Git, reviewed against the PRD, and verified through real commands, tests, builds, packaged application runs, and generated files.

Two independent review passes were used as quality gates. Their findings led to concrete fixes in persistence ordering, local-midnight behavior, vault retry, Electron sandboxing, path safety, runtime validation, and Markdown integrity. The final independent reviews reported no material requirement failures, security concerns, or logic errors.

No AI-generated character artwork was used. Credentials and secret values were not included in the repository or report.

8. Reflection

The most important lesson was that combining two simple tools creates difficult state boundaries. A task list and a timer are individually straightforward, but reliable recurrence, restart recovery, append-only history, and unavailable-folder behavior require explicit models.

Timestamp-derived timer state was more reliable than saving a displayed countdown. The same principle applied to Obsidian delivery: creating a local event first and treating the vault as a retryable destination made offline behavior predictable.

The review process also changed the implementation substantially. The first working version passed its initial unit tests, but independent review found important issues that normal happy-path testing had missed: unfinished one-off tasks disappearing, recurrence templates becoming stale, UTC/local-date

mismatches, persistence races, overly trusted renderer input, and a configured vault being forgotten during an outage. Fixing those issues improved both correctness and the depth of the project.

If I continued the project, I would add automated desktop tests for crossing midnight while the app remains open, native folder-picker interaction, notification delivery, and running/paused timer restoration across a full quit and relaunch. I would also create a signed build, a custom icon, richer history filters, and optional supported macOS Focus integration.

9. Limitations

- The first version targets macOS only.
- The packaged application is unsigned and uses Electron Builder's default icon.
- macOS Focus/Do Not Disturb integration is deferred; the app includes an in-app distraction-free mode.
- Completion progress is implemented, but streak scoring is deferred.
- There is no cloud sync, account system, collaboration, or cross-device support.
- The final assessment sample is a copy of genuine local app output; the planning journal remains separate.

10. Conclusion

Gentleday meets the assignment goal as one functional offline desktop application rather than two disconnected prototypes. It combines personal task management and focus tracking, preserves state across restarts, records honest active duration, and writes durable append-only history into a user-owned Obsidian vault.

The project moved through research, Grill decisions, approved design references, implementation, independent review, real-app evidence generation, clean-clone verification, and macOS packaging. The result is a small but complete local productivity system shaped around the user's actual routine and assessed through repeatable evidence rather than screenshots alone.

Sources

[1] <https://www.todoist.com/task-management> — Todoist task management

[2] <https://quiere.io/features> — Quire features

[3] <https://help.evernote.com/hc/en-us/articles/1500003792141-Tasks-Overview> — Evernote Tasks overview

[4] <https://www.forestapp.cc> — Forest focus app

[5] <https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=pomotime.idealapps.ge> — PomoTime listing

[6] <https://pomofocus.io> — Pomofocus